

Chapter 4

The ice rink seemed colder when a lone otter perched upon a hard, plastic blue seat, intended for temporary comfort only. The colour did not help, chilling the circle of the rink to, well, freezing temperatures. For some bizarre reason that Liam could not fathom, some chairs were randomly formed of yellow plastic, dotted throughout the stands without method in the madness of their placing. There may have been some logic behind it, perhaps replacing broken seats when their time came, but none that the otter could deduce without further information.

Shivering, he huddled deeper into his holey fleece – it could have been religious – for what little warmth he could glean from it. He should have brought his coat. The otter grumbled and hunched forward, peering through the netting encircling the rink, which shielded viewers from flying pucks where the plexi glass came to an end. It would have made more sense to him to have the glass all the way around the rink, though netting was likely a cheaper option. He only hoped nothing would fly over the top of it.

He sat alone on a chair that was at the same level as the rink, studying the audience around him as they clustered together in small groups that had arrived together. He could only assume that each individual group supported a single player, consisting of family and friends where applicable. Ice hockey did not appear to discern between species and all manner of furs had turned up for the game, some clasping hot drinks between their paws and others cracking open cans of beer already. Liam's mouth was dry and he licked his lips in an attempt to wet them.

Despite the surprising number of furs attending the game, there were more empty seats than claimed ones and that fact alone set the audience apart from that of a professional game. Liam had seen the crowds flocking to the rink upon many occasions when the professional home team was playing, though their name once again eluded him. Working at the rink, it was a name that he really should have known after his time there.

The players – white and blue against red and black, warmed up on the ice, muscles pumping with blood. Once their helmets were on, individual furs were nearly indistinguishable from one another with only body shapes and specialist skates (designed differently for different anthro species') allowing some distinction. Their jerseys played a greater role in identification, numbers and surnames standing out proudly on the backs of the home team in royal blue. The otter frowned. He had never thought to ask what Darren's surname was. That was a bind.

The wolf, however, pre-empted the difficulty before it even became an issue. A single skater stopped on the edge of his blade and scanned the crowd, helmet turning obviously. Raising a paw, he waved like a pup to his parents in the audience of the school play, grey tail wagging in a blur. Tentatively, Liam lifted his paw in return, moving it from left to right, twice only. Darren Baker, as became evident, called two teammates to him, a horse, who was identified by his distinctive hoof suitable skates, and a lion with tufts of mane sticking out of his helmet. They looked across to the stands, following Darren's line of sight, and joined him in waving, sliding to and fro on their skates. Liam chuckled and shook his head at their antics. They must have felt in good spirits about the game.

It was strange to be waved at.

He shifted, plastic seat hard against his backside. He never frequented the flip-down rink seats if he could help it, choosing the break room chairs for a well earned rest instead during work hours. Work was too busy anyway for sitting around.

The teams sorted themselves with the guidance of the referees, garbed in black and white striped uniforms, and their coaches until only a select few were left on the ice. A canine of some kind from the Solihull team faced off against Swindon on either side of a circle that was placed right in the centre of the rink. Not yet knowing how the game would progress, Liam slouched in his seat, wriggling until his tail slipped to the side of the chair into a marginally more comfortable position. He could just about see the two players in the centre staring each other down and imagined their eyes narrowing, intimidating each other in the heat of the moment, the only manner of intimidation that was allowed. Though hockey was known for physical violence, Liam had been suitably informed in no uncertain terms that any fighting would result in penalties and bans, neither of which either team desired.

The feline referee skated between them – not too shabby with his blade work – with the puck in one paw. The second ref, an older bear with grey hairs in his muzzle, kept his distance, eyes roaming the rink watchfully. Liam wondered why they needed two refs when the rink was not all that large, simply standard ice hockey rink size for the professional teams to play.

The puck dropped and the canine lunged for it, slapping away the puck before the Swindon player was able to react. Leaping back on his skates, the referee spun and chased the players, long, feline tail lashing the air to his rear. He was some kind of spotted cat with a base of yellow fur but Liam was not knowledgeable enough to tell whether he was a leopard or a jaguar as he near enough flew across the rink, keeping pace with the players while staying out of their way.

Passing the puck, the canine shouted to a younger looking badger, his striped face identifiable behind the helmet. The puck bounced off his skates with a sharp rap and skidded around for the badger to flail for, stick jabbing out wildly. Liam bit his lip to hide a grin as the badger lost his balance, arm stuck out straight for balance that he could not quite seem to catch. Whether the badger needed more practice in skating or puck handling remained to be seen, yet Liam could not fault him for trying.

The canine with a narrow muzzle – Furrow – coolly skated around in a wide arc and scooped up the puck to drop it neatly into the net as the keeper blinked. Liam smirked. Too slow! Much too slow! It was a neat shot and the dog raised his fist in the air jubilant, gloves covering his paws to the arm of the jersey so that not a scrap of fur could be seen. Another teammate bumped his fist in passing. Liam leaned forward, watching the path their skates cut through the ice.

He could skate with that finesse.

Shivering, he licked his lips and settled in to watch the first ‘period’ as Darren had informed him it was called. Lines changed – another titbit of hastily shared knowledge in too short a time – and the grey wolf dashed on to the ice, going for the puck with his jaw set into a determined line. He skidded to a halt and struck off in the opposite direction, moving with speed that Liam envied in his static position. Darren barely got two strides, however, and was flattened into the boards by a bulk wolf on the opposing time, disappearing briefly from sight.

He crashed to the ice and bounded up a moment later as if it had not hurt in the slightest, a grin on his muzzle. Despite being aware of all the padding and protective gear the players had to wear for safety and insurance reasons, Liam still winced in sympathy. It was a rough sport for those involved.

Digging his paws into his pockets, Liam wormed a finger into a tiny hole, eyes fixed on the action. One of the Solihull players – a forward? What was the term? – swung desperately at the puck, sending it skimming down the ice too wide of the opposing team's goal. The keeper raised his paw with a shake of his head to the referee's whistle. The otter wracked his brain as the players returned to a circle at the other end of the rink. Though he had received a very swift run through on the rules of ice hockey back in the rink cafe, it was difficult to absorb everything over multiple glasses of terrible G & T. The otter scratched the back of his head and muttered a curse under his breath.

Icing. That's what it was!

Liam could not keep the grin from his muzzle as the minutes ticked by on the clock, the hour growing ever later. The amateur teams had to play much later so that the professionals raked in the money for the rink, though it seemed a sorry deal at times for the amateurs who showed their devotion to the sport. Darren had told him that one game on the South coast had started at half past twelve! At night! And that was a good run on a clear road from the Midlands to get there and back in time, though what one would be in time for Liam could not fathom at that hour. The otter didn't think he could have stuck those hours. He liked his sleep too much.

As the first period melded into the second and then the third, Liam inched further and further forward on his seat until he clung on to the plastic by his fingertips. He watched the players huddle, discussing the score of the first and second periods, tensions rising as the score tied at three points to each team. It would have been easier if one had taken a clear lead, dominance over the game, to balance out the frustration of being so close yet so far. As it was, each team wanted to win as much, if not more, than the other, which was a contradiction in itself that Liam wholly understood. The Solihull keeper shook his head grimly and cast his eyes over the rink, lips moving to form words that Liam was a shade too far away to catch. They were not intended for him anyway, though Liam wondered if it was something to do with the number of players, considering they did not even have a full four lines. The strain showed in their panted breaths, frosting in the air as they huffed.

The referee blew the whistle, calling them back to the centre of the rink for the third and final period. The teams sprung into action once more, forcing exhausted muscles to push a little harder for one to two minutes at a time. It was not that great a span, truly, yet to a tired fur that extreme burst of motion on the ice could feel like an hour. Line changes were swift and, though Liam's heart hammered against his ribcage every time a player went down on the ice from a particularly rough check, he ached to be down there with them. His eyes shone.

Liam had never been much of a watcher.

The Solihull Dragons dropped the puck neatly in the back of the net in the last five minutes, scoring cheers from the team and supporting home crowd. The scoring player, a lion that Liam wagered he had clocked waving with Darren earlier, grinned fiercely and exchanged a

fist bump with Darren, who had assisted in scoring the goal. The team on the bench banged their sticks against the boards in ruthless, deafening applause. What good was clapping their paws when they were gloved for the conditions and play? That would be too polite a cheer – muted! Liam resisted the impulse to cover his ears, tail thumping his legs in discomfort. He hated how his ears were sensitive to noise. Belatedly, he remembered his headphones left on the dining table, thrown casually across after his last sprint at the rink.

No matter. He sat up straighter. The game was almost over.

Liam cheered with the rest of the scattered Solihull supporters as the buzzer screamed and the home team erupted in celebration, throwing their sticks on the ice. Stripping off gloves and helmets, fur stuck to their heads and skin red beneath fur, the winning team lined up and met the other with shakes of their paws. Darren beamed, ears pricked as he shook each paw in turn. After all, it was only a friendly game and there was no true animosity between the teams. Things had not even got as heated as Darren had warned him.

Though the fact that it was a friendly game could be a little tricky to remember when they were checking each other into the boards. Liam smirked.

One thing was sure at the conclusion of the game, as fur of the match was announced and beer presented to the best players from each team.

Liam wanted *in*. There would be no more sitting on the sidelines for him.

The otter slouched back on his seat and flexed his paws, no longer feeling the cold.

When could he start?

*

“Easy now!”

Darren laughed as Liam dragged his sweaty form across the car park outside the rink, demonstrating surprising strength for a comparatively small otter. His fur stuck up in all directions and he smelled decidedly ripe, making Liam wrinkle his nose impolitely, despite trying to turn his muzzle discreetly away. Having made the mistake of telling Liam that there was a NHL – National Hockey League – game on that night, starting at the genteel time of one in the morning. And Liam set his heart on watching it. Sure, it was late but, hell, it was a night for impulsive actions! After considering that he didn’t start work until Sunday afternoon, that is, and that Darren didn’t work at all on the weekends. A calculated impulse, one could say.

“You’re staying to watch the game, right?” Liam asked without thinking.

Pausing, Darren followed close on Liam’s heels as he leapt up the steps to his flat, taking them two at a time in his burst of energy. Fumbling the key into the lock, Liam wriggled his fingers, which were stiff with cold, striving to stir some warmth back into sore digits. Gloves would be an idea next time.

Leading the way into his humble abode, Liam hoped the wolf did not think it too quaint with its four rooms: living room, kitchen, bathroom and bedroom. It was sparsely furnished to the extent that Liam required it to be, though it was not as if there was any money going spare for furniture that he bet would be disposed of in a few years time when he moved next. To him, nothing more than what he already had was needed but he did not want Darren to think that he lived in squalor, what with his high flying sales for job. The wolf clearly had a lot more money than him, even if Darren claimed in passing that he did not care about money, it was merely a passing commodity to him. As it was, Liam squirmed out of his coat and hung it on the hook behind the door, holding his breath lest Darren notice his chest heaving in worried pants.

The wolf followed suit and dropped his hockey bag a few paces further in beside the sofa, taking in the room, which could be judged in a single glance. Cringing under the scrutiny of his private space, Liam dashed into the narrow kitchen with white nineties units and busied himself with the kettle.

“Tea?” He called through to the living room, voice unnecessarily loud with a higher pitch towards the end of the word that made him wince.

“Small place,” Darren replied without answering the initial question, voice muffled as he investigated something in the petite living room.

“Not enough space to swing a weasel,” Liam confirmed with a shaky laugh that broke at the tail end. “Would you like tea?”

Darren poked his muzzle through the doorway into the kitchen with a wolfish grin.

“Got anything a bit stronger?”

Liam’s ear twitched.

“Maybe?” He tapped the side of his muzzle, grin spreading. “Let me see what I can do about that for you.”

As Darren disappeared back into the living room, Liam crouched to reach right to the back of one barely used cupboard, crammed with stock food that he barely found time to use these days. Who had time to cook if it took more than a few minutes? He was thin enough as it was and the otter could use all the extra calories from healthier options that he could get. Nevertheless, he felt a twinge of guilt as he pushed aside budget tins of tomatoes and pasta to reach further in, knees pressed to the cold, hard tile floor. Linoleum would have been a better option for the kitchen but it was his fate, apparently, to live in ever increasingly old fashioned homes.

Scrabbling for space, he pressed his shoulder to the counter, grasping the four-pack of beer he knew was secluded beside another in the corner, just difficult enough to reach that he would not be too tempted on a daily basis or any normal occasion. Once, it had been several cans a day that disappeared down his throat and lightened his wallet. But that time was not worth remembering.

Liam shook himself and, having retrieved the cans, collected two pint glasses from the draining board. He trotted back through to the living room – a few steps away – with his prize cradled in one paw and the glasses pinched between the fingers of his other paw, glass clinking rather non-musically. Even though they were pint glasses, best suited to alcohol, he preferred to use them for water, glugging as much of it daily as he could to make himself feel fuller than he was.

“Here you go,” he said, handing a can and glass to Darren, balancing them between his body and a paw.

Furrowing his brow in concentration, he could not give Darren only one glass and tried to readjust the cans, one threatening to take an untimely tumble to the bleached out brown carpet. That would be fun to open if it became all shaken up. Helpfully, Darren quickly collected his glass and one can, dropping them on the square coffee table beside the sofa – which had seen better days – and took the glass from the otter, lightening his load. Their paws brushed and the wolf grinned, tongue lolling from his muzzle as Liam’s cheeks heated up.

“Thanks,” he mumbled, casting his gaze down.

Darren’s ears flicked to catch his words, directed away from him. Studying the carpet, Liam brought the can in closer to his chest, fiddling with the pull tab. He really hated that carpet. Had Darren noticed how old the carpet was?

“Not a problem,” the wolf replied easily. “So...” His grin grew. “About this game you wanted to watch...”

Liam perked up and ran to the little television set, which was, of course, a blocky hand-me-down that he had acquired from a cousin before the big move across the country. He would never have paid out on something as frivolous as a television and it was not much to look at anyway. Switching it on, he reached for the remote only for the wolf to rest a paw on his forearm, gently steadying him in his eagerness.

Liam tried not to think about how good that paw felt.

“What’s up?”

“Game won’t be on TV if it’s NHL,” Darren explained with a quick glance around the room. “Do you have a laptop?”

Liam cringed. Not very likely, considering the state of his flat and possessions. What was Darren thinking? His heartbeat fluttered and he struggled to calm it, surreptitiously pressing a paw over his heart. His palms were clammy with sweat and he took several calming breaths, tilting his head as if in thought. It was enough to buy him a few seconds while he controlled the ever present anxiety, always a hair’s breadth below the surface.

“Will a computer do?”

Darren laughed in a flash of white canines that made Liam’s heart beat more regularly again, yet harder. It was not an entirely unpleasant feeling and he chanced a smile.

Stop that, he told himself sternly. You're acting like a cub. So cut it the hell out! We are so not fucking going there. You know what happened last time.

His muzzle dropped a fraction, chin tilting down as his eyes clouded over, memories fighting to be heard.

It's not like that this time. Darren is a friend. And should stay that way, if I'm lucky.

"Of course a computer will be fine," the wolf chuckled, not privy to Liam's inner conversation and turmoil. "Why on earth wouldn't it be?"

"Um, I don't know?" The otter fumbled for words. "Better screen, maybe?"

Glancing at the decrepit box of a computer gather a fine layer of dust (he never thought to dust the back side of the screen) in the corner of the room, Darren half-shrugged and rolled his shoulders back.

"As long as it does its job, hey? That's all the computer is for. Kind of had you pegged for the gaming type."

"I did like it," Liam mused, only half listening to his own words as he booted up the PC, brushing a paw surreptitiously over the square desk, checking for dust. "But it's expensive to keep up with all the new games."

"I've got a few if you ever fancy coming over to play," Darren offered. "Though I have to warn you, most I've nicked from my brother. He never misses them!"

Darren chuckled and shook his head.

"Spends all his money on games and never plays them. Reckon it's his girlfriend that doesn't give him time to play, if you know what I mean."

The otter shook his head in turn at that comment, wondering for not the first time which way Darren 'swung' when it came to relationships. The wolf was not one to give anything away, though Liam had no doubt that he would reveal all if only he asked. But Liam was not one to ask.

He seated himself at the desk, swivelling back and forth a few times. It did not squeak or make any noise at all, in surprisingly good condition for his flat – an online auction purchase that he was particularly proud of snapping up. Wheeling it home down the high street, however, had been a different matter.

As Liam set up himself up, Darren darted into the kitchen and returned an instant later with a wooden chair hefted in two paws. When Liam raised an eyebrow in unspoken question, the wolf shrugged and plopped the chair down beside the office chair Liam perched on so tentatively that one may have thought he feared it would burn his rump.

"Though I spotted it in the kitchen," the wolf explained. "Will be easier to sit at the computer, I think. Not on the sofa. If we're using the computer, that is."

It was strange to hear the normally confident wolf slip over his words and Liam pretended not to notice, clicking on to his easiest internet browser.

“You have a quick eye,” he commented. “You didn’t even go into the kitchen, not really.”

“Thanks. Have to have a quick eye for the little things, especially in hockey.”

“Mm,” Liam murmured, distracted. “So...what site do I go to?”

“Finally loaded up?”

“Heh, yeah, takes long enough though.”

Liam had the good grace to chuckle but could not stop the hot flush of embarrassment from searing his skin, cheeks heating up. Thank god for fur.

Unknowing, Darren scooted the straight backed chair in close to Liam’s, tail wriggling through the gap in the wooden slats. He leaned forward on the desk to take control of the mouse, lips barely parted as he pulled up a buffering online stream of the game in question, five minutes in to the first period. At least the interest was of a good speed, regardless of the age of the desktop computer in question. A laptop would have fared worse at the end of the day.

The wolf wagged his tail, brushing against the otter’s, which draped over the side of the swivel chair. Freezing, Liam stared straight ahead and pretended not to notice, focusing on the players. He put together what knowledge he had stirred up from watching the amateur game, quietly interlinking the pieces that he was sure he knew, like icing and all that. Liam popped the snap tag back on his beer can and poured it into the glass with the most level paws he could manage, cold sweat trickling beneath his fur.

The tail did not move away from his as he took his first glug, then a long draught and then drained the glass. There was more in the back of the cupboard and Liam did not so much mind drinking in company. It would be needed with the wolf around. Darren shuffled closer, knee bumping his and tail resting ever so casually where it could have been an accident or a deliberate touch.

Swallowing hard, Liam hardly watched the game.

Only time would tell if it was an accident...or not.